INTERNATIONAL AGENCIES

International agencies were active in providing electoral assistance to the UEC, political parties, and a variety of CSOs in anticipation of the 2015 election. The primary agency providing financial and technical assistance was USAID. It coordinated activities with the United Kingdom's Department for International Development and Australia's Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade. They provided funding for the International Foundation for Electoral Systems (IFES), the National Democratic Institute (NDI), and the International Republican Institute's (IRI) operations in the country. Furthermore, European Union support included grants to civil society groups, media training, police training, and technical assistance to the UEC in drafting the Code of Conduct for election observers (Myanma Alin 2015).

Ahead of the election, the NDI provided technical assistance to Myanmar's parliament through the creation of a Parliamentary Resource Center in Naypyitaw, and training to strengthen parliamentary processes and the reform agenda. NDI also worked with CSOs to facilitate peer-to peer training and best practices. NDI trained some 5,000 citizens as election observers to monitor electoral processes before and during election day (NDI 2015).

IRI focuses on strengthening political parties. It provided training workshops to all parties — from the NLD and USDP to small ethnic parties — to teach them how to conduct campaigns, organize internal party structures, and develop party platforms. It also supported civil society groups engaged in voter and civic education campaigns.

In addition, with funding from Norway, the International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance (IDEA), together with the Danish Institute for Parties and Democracy, and Democracy Reporting International operated in Myanmar on a new 2015 electoral trust-building initiative. IDEA also provided technical assistance to the UEC via workshops on how to use IDEA's Electoral Risk Management tool, to identify potential trouble areas before the election.

In 1990 and 2010, foreign observers were not allowed to monitor and scrutinize general elections. In the 2012 by-election, only observers from Southeast Asian countries were invited. Thus, 2015 marked the first time in Myanmar's election history that international observers other than those from nearby countries were invited. In total, the UEC issued accreditation